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| <b>(1) Research Program/Project/Study Title:</b><br><b>Profiling, Assessment and Promotion of River Tour Industry along the Riverine of Roxas City Capiz</b> |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
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Program or Project has component (if no proceed to 2)? ☐ Yes ☒ No

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| <b>Component Title:</b>  |  |
| <b>Component Leader:</b> |  |
| <b>Academic Rank:</b>    |  |

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| <b>(2) Category (please check)</b><br><input checked="" type="checkbox"/> Social Science/Education /Humanities & other related fields<br><input type="checkbox"/> Natural/Biological Sciences<br><input type="checkbox"/> Food Research/<br><input type="checkbox"/> Developmental/ Computer/Engineering/ Architecture<br><input type="checkbox"/> Extension<br><input type="checkbox"/> Poster | <b>(3) Research Center</b><br>[Check the concerned center]<br><input checked="" type="checkbox"/> SSITRDC<br>Social Science and Industrial<br>Technology Research Development<br>Center<br><input type="checkbox"/> LRDC<br>Livestock Research Development<br>Center<br><input type="checkbox"/> FFRDC<br>Fisheries and Food Research<br>Development Center<br><input type="checkbox"/> CSRDC<br>Crop Science Research Development<br>Center |
| <b>(4) Site of implementation</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| Municipality/City:                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>Roxas City</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Province:                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Capiz</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
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| <b>(5) Classification</b><br><br><div style="display: flex; justify-content: space-between;"> <div style="width: 45%;"> <b>Research:</b><br/> <input checked="" type="checkbox"/> Basic<br/> <input type="checkbox"/> Applied         </div> <div style="width: 45%;"> <b>Development:</b><br/> <input type="checkbox"/> Pilot Testing<br/> <input type="checkbox"/> Tech. Promotion/Commercialization         </div> </div>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | <b>(6) Mode of Implementation</b><br><br><input type="checkbox"/> Single Authorship/Proponent<br><input checked="" type="checkbox"/> Collaborative Research (within campus)<br><input type="checkbox"/> Collaborative Research (intercampus)<br><input type="checkbox"/> Collaborative Research (external agency) |
| <b>(7) Sector/Commodity</b><br><br>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | <b>(8) Discipline/Field of Specialization</b><br><br>Social Science                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| <b>(9A) Abstract</b><br><br><p>The study was conducted to explore the profiling of services, assessment, and promotion of the river tour industry along the riverine of Roxas City, Capiz. The participatory action research method of the qualitative research design was used in this study and the results were thematically analyzed. The participants were the members of the river tour operators of Palina and Cadimahan. The training and capacity building and infrastructure development for the riverine communities of Palina and Cadimahan Roxas City, Capiz was the feasible intervention programs of the study.</p>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>(9B) Keywords</b><br><i>Profiling, Assessment and Promotion, River Tour Operators, Sustainable River Tourism, Roxas City, Capiz</i>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>(10) Introduction</b><br><p>Ecotourism is one method for promoting conservation and generating money for local communities in and near protected areas. It can aid economic growth and protect protected areas by producing funds to manage protected areas sustainably, creating jobs in the region, and fostering a sense of community ownership (Jalani, 2012).</p> <p>In the Philippines, it features a variety of unique river tourist spots. Some provide leisurely cruises throughout its length, where tourists may view the local fauna and flora. Others provide opportunities for water sports. It has transformed into a tourist location for viewing and photographing flora and animals (Webb, 2016).</p> <p>The island of Bohol, the Loboc River, offers a river tour with a floating restaurant and an accompanying musical ensemble. This tranquil location along the Meycauyan River's bank, North Riverside Resort, and Leisure Park make it desirable to come. The Subterranean River National Park is located about 50 kilometers north of Puerto Princesa, Palawan. It is an underground river with a navigable length of 8.2 km that is located inside a huge cave with several chambers. With a pristine lagoon near its mouth, it boasts several stalactite and stalagmite formations. The most recent list of candidates for the "New 7 Wonders of Nature" includes this subterranean river at the top (Torrefranca et al., 2020).</p> <p>In Panay Island, various river tour operators have been documented by the Department of Tourism; this includes the Palina Greenbelt Ecopark and Cadimahan river tour operators along the Roxas City, Capiz riverine communities. The river tour operators preserved a variety of coastal ecosystems for long-term aquaculture and fisheries. The Eco-Park and its members receive income based on incentives; shared profits have distributed among the members, and the other shares go toward improving the infrastructure. It is a tourist attraction that generates revenue for the local communities that support it. They provided a wide range of attractions for visitors to enjoy before the pandemic (Capiz Provincial Tourism, 2022).</p> <p>The operations have been suspended since March 2020 because of the pandemic and have only recently resumed in October 2021. Activities were restricted, and the floating rafts could only operate at half of their capacity. The survival of the river ecotourism ecosystem is compromised without continued government support. The governments have taken impressive steps to cushion the blow to tourism, minimize job losses, and build recovery in 2021 in a more coordinated manner. The response to the coronavirus pandemic mentioned in the local river tour operator is developing measures to build a more resilient river tourism economy post-COVID-19. These include preparing plans to support the sustainable recovery of river tourism, promoting the digital transition and moving to a greener river tourism system, and rethinking tourism for the future (Quang, T.T. et al., 2021).</p> |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |

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The paper intended to profile and assess services, distinguish the ways of promotion, and identified the appropriate interventions and programs for sustainable ecotourism of the Cadimahan and Palina river tour industry along the Riverine of Roxas City Capiz.

This study explored the profiling of the river tour services, assessment of services in the new normal, identified the ways of promoting the river tour services, and formulated the appropriate intervention programs for developing sustainable river tourism.

It sought to answer the following specific questions:

1. What are the services offered by the river tour operators before the occurrence of the pandemic?
2. What is the status of the river tour services of the river tour in the new normal?
3. In what ways the river tour services can be promoted in the new normal?
4. What intervention/s can be designed to develop sustainable ecotourism?

## **(11) Materials and Methods or Methodology**

### **Research Design**

The participatory action research design was used in this study. The design was utilized in gathering the data, which focuses on profiling the services of the river tour, assessment, promotion, and taking action on the identified interventions based on the data gathered from the river tour operators (Lewin,1948).

The nature of the data collected was qualitative. Qualitative data defines traits and attributes. This information is often gathered through interviews, observations, surveys, or questionnaires and appears narratively. Furthermore, the data may be in descriptive terms that may be coded to look for patterns or meaning (Dewitt, 2020).

### **Participants of the Study**

The participants in this study were ten (10) members from the Palina and Cadimahan river tour operators along the Roxas City, Capiz River. The study used purposive sampling in the identification and selection of the participants. Purposive sampling or judgment selective sampling is a form of non-probability sampling in which the researchers rely on their judgment when selecting members of the population to participate in the study (Saunders, Lewis & Thornhill, 2012).

**Table 1. Profile of the River Tour Members of Palina and Cadimahan, Roxas City**

| <b>Name of the River Tour Member</b> | <b>Age</b> | <b>Educational Attainment</b> |
|--------------------------------------|------------|-------------------------------|
| PAPC01                               | 69         | Elementary Level              |
| PAPC02                               | 66         | High School Level             |
| PAPC03                               | 38         | College Level                 |
| PAPP04                               | 36         | High School Graduate          |
| PAPP05                               | 38         | College Graduate              |
| PAPP06                               | 70         | Elementary Graduate           |
| PAPP07                               | 57         | College Level                 |
| PAPP08                               | 26         | College Graduate              |
| PAPP09                               | 27         | College Level                 |
| PAPP10                               | 52         | College Level                 |

The participant selection criteria were delimited to study the participants who: a) active members of the Palina and Cadimahan river tour operators for the last past (5) five years; (b) are fisherfolks and residents of Palina and Cadimahan, Roxas City; and (c) fits the characteristic criteria as determined through researchers' professional judgment and the objective opinions of the researchers' colleagues.

The research instrument used to gather data was a set of researcher-made open-ended questions to gather the participants' responses about the services and assessment of river tour operators.

The questions were focused on the different involvements of the members of the river tour operators. There were (3) three key questions in this study wanted to find out through the individual answers of the participants. They were identified as (1) What are the services offered by the river tour operators before the occurrence of the pandemic? (2) What is the status of the river tour services of the river tour in the new normal? (3) In what ways do the river tour services can be promoted in the new normal?

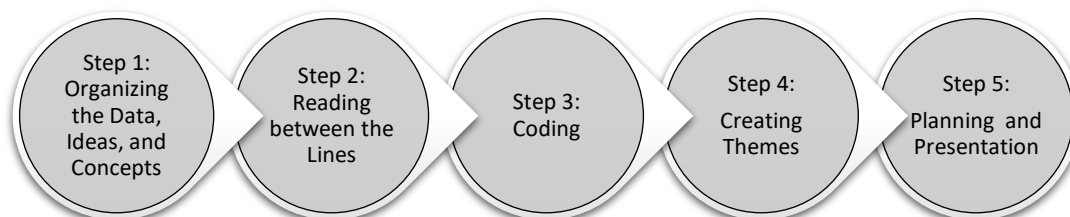
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After the survey was conducted, the data responses were analyzed using content analysis. The responses were divided into four (4) categories from the key questions, namely (1) profile of the participants; (2) services offered by the river tour operators; (3) assessment of services of the river tour; and (4) ways of promoting the river tour services.

#### Data Analysis Procedure

In analyzing the data gathered from the survey, the following steps of Sutton and Austin (2015) were observed. The thematic analysis procedures are shown in Table 2.

**Figure 1. Steps in Thematic Analysis**



The first step was organizing the data, ideas, and concepts. The survey's design is the best way to arrange the data. The researchers sorted the data through the question after collecting the participants' responses to look for patterns and contradictions in the responses.

The second step was reading between the lines. The researchers grasp the meaning of the participants assigned to their experiences since the study used a phenomenological method, which informed the data analysis. In this phase, the researchers analyzed the significance of the responses within the context of the study. This process involved getting underneath the participants' answers to truly understand the world from the participants' perspective.

The third step was coding. The subjects, problems, similarities, and variations that emerged from the participants' narratives were noted by the researchers. Through this technique, the researchers were better capable of understanding the world from each participant's perspective. The coding process was done on a hard copy of the transcript of the participants' answers by making notes in the margin or by highlighting and naming parts of the text.

The fourth step was creating over-arching themes in the data. Different categories were grouped under one main theme because all participants' responses to each question contain one or more connected themes.

The researchers discovered additional themes that acted as sub-categories as they continued to classify the data. This procedure was carried out repeatedly until all relevant topics had been found and classified. To ensure dependability and validity in the data analysis, the researchers identified able to thoroughly review the responses that had been gathered.

The last step was planning out the way the findings are going to be presented. To provide a thorough explanation of the phenomenon, the researchers made assumptions based on the participant's narratives. In discussing the assumptions, the researchers made sure to include possible and plausible explanations by going back to the literatures cited.

## (12) Results and Discussions

The researchers were able to conduct an interview with the ten (10) members of the Cadimahan and Palina Green Belt Eco- Park river tour operator.

#### Profile of the Participants

The profile of the participants of the study is shown in Table 1. As reflected in the table, there were 10 participants in this study. Of the 10 participants, three (3) were from the Cadimahan river tour. The seven (7) participants were from the Palina Greenbelt Eco- Park River tour.

The members of the river tour operators are mostly middle-old age adults in terms of age groups. All of them were not able to finish college and two (2) were able to finish a college degree. They are mostly from the family of fisherfolks who operated the river tour for a long time.

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### Services offered by the River Tour Operators

The river tour operators offer a diverse range of food services which includes breakfast, lunch, snacks, and drinks. It has a menu that includes traditional local cuisine from starters and cold dishes. The menu gives an overview of various food items that are prepared and served. Menu compiling is one of the most important jobs for river tour operators. All activities in the food service unit are influenced by the menu.

*“Ang river tour, may ara man foods nga gina offer ang Palena, pamahaw, panyaga kag may ara man snacks. Ga provide kami sir sang menu para makita sang customer kon ano nabaligya” (FGDP01).*

The river tour operators have floating raft wellness that offers massage to the tourist which is to provide relaxation, increases body awareness, and creates balance with the objectives of promoting health and wellness. The massage services have a long history in cultures among the river tour operators. It has different types of massage for a variety of health-related purposes offered.

*“May massage man diri, foot massage, body massage, kung sa diin didto sila sir sa home wellness namon ginaakomodar para sa damo klasi nga massage” (FGDP03).*

It offers manicures and pedicures for curation and care of a tourist's hands and feet. This includes skincare, nail care, and artificial nail enhancements that can be customized to a variety of preferences.

*“Kung gusto man nila sir sang iban namon nga serbisyo ga offer man kami sir manicure kag pedicure” (FGD04).*

Tourists may reserve the floating restaurant for a cruise experience or rent it without a reservation once available. The river tour operators will provide fresh seafood plates on the raft on bamboo benches upon request by the tourists to relax and enjoy the breeze. Each floating restaurant contains tables and seats for a cruise-like experience. Other services are offered such as mangrove planting.

*“Kun wala may nagpareserve sir sang raft kag available man, pwedi gid ini magamit sang mga turista nga gakadto sa amon. Ang floating raft sir, may mga bangko kg pungkuan man sir kung sa diin makapungko ang customer samtang gahulat sang ila nga pagkaon nga gin order. Luwas sina sir, may river tour kag mangrove planting man sir kami nga gina offer” (FGD08).*

The thematic analysis of the statements of the participants regarding the river tour services before the occurrence of the pandemic is shown in Table 2.

**Table 2. River Tour Operators Services**

| CODE              | CATEGORY                | Theme(s) Extracted                                |
|-------------------|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Foods             | Food Services           | Services based on Tangible and Intangible Actions |
| Massage           | Health Care Services    |                                                   |
| Foot Spa          | River Tour Services     |                                                   |
| Manicure/Pedicure | Demo/Lecture Services   |                                                   |
| Floating raft     | Community Participation |                                                   |
| Tour              |                         |                                                   |
| Mangrove Planting |                         |                                                   |

### Assessments of Services of the River Tour in the New Normal

According to the river tour operators, they provide great services to the tourists. However, they need to improve the waiting time for the orders and the floating raft subject to maintenance to provide a better experience to the tourists. The river tour operators need to ensure that the rafts are well-maintained and in good condition.

*“Based sa amon logbook sir, may ara man kakulangan amon serbisyo kun kaisa madugay ang order nila kay tungod kis-a on the spot ang pagorder, kag nakadepindi sa foods nga ginaluto. Kulang kang samad ang amon iban na raft facilities sir para makomodar sang customer” (FGDP07).*

The participant, says that the overall services were good, however, most of them still have not recovered from the damage caused by the typhoon. The post-pandemic created a huge problem mostly with the lack of customers and tourists. They are also facing economic difficulties because they are not able to operate at full capacity.

*“Okay gd sir amon services. Ang amon sir iban na facilities sir guba kag during sadtong after pandemic sir indi kami maka amodar sang damo nga customer tungod sa health protocols muna naghina amon serbisyo kag kita sir” (FGDP05).*

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The thematic analysis of the statements of the participants regarding the status of the river tour services of the river tour in the new normal is shown in Table 3.

**Table 3. Assessment of Services of the River Tour Operators**

| CODE                           | CATEGORY        | Theme(s) Extracted              |
|--------------------------------|-----------------|---------------------------------|
| Meeting tourists' expectations | Good Services   | Tourists' Positive and Negative |
| Lack of raft maintenance       | Poor Facilities | Feedback                        |

The researchers searched to verify the participants' claims, based on the findings from the customer feedback, tourism customer review sites (e.g., TripAdvisor, Google reviews,) and social media sites (e.g., Facebook, etc.), it shows that the average satisfaction level of the tourists is average. The level of satisfaction of the tourists is average in terms of the safety of the tour operation, the tour guides, the food, the accommodation, and the tour cost. The level of satisfaction of the tourists is low in terms of the facilities and equipment of the river tour operators.

#### **Ways to Promote River Tour Services in the New Normal**

The river tour operators created a unique local tourism promotion through social media which is a considerable to increase in the number of river tour bookings. The introduction of this sightseeing river tour has helped the local tourism sector solve issues relating to alternative tourism activity.

*"May mga Facebook user sir nga ga posting sila sang ila aktibidad sa river tour, then gina tag daun kami sir, kg gin approved namon as public para makita man sang iban sir" (FGDP01).*

The river tour operators use social media like Facebook which is a way to spread the services to tourists. It's also easy for people to share their experiences with friends through social media posts which can help create more demand for the river tour operators' local ecotourism business. Not only will it see an increase in tourists, however it saves money by not having to invest in other expensive advertising campaigns or print ads since everything is online these days. Social media platforms offer a variety of promotional tools that can be used to market a business. These tools can be used to create and share content, track engagement, and measure results.

*"Gina post namon sa facebook sir ang amon iban nga activities. Gina probaydan namon sang pictures ang post kag ginabutangan caption bas ikon ano ang ara sa pictures sir" (FGDP010).*

The initiatives come from Philippine national TV such as ABS-CBN, TV5, GMA7, and SMNI through airing promotional content of river tour operators on national TV for free. Some of these include using video clips, trailers, and even an entire episode of a show. Additionally, using social media platforms such as YouTube and Facebook can also be beneficial in getting exposure for a promotional video.

*"Huo bale, ang GMA kag ABS CBN nag kwaa di samun. Ka duwa nadi nagbalik sa amon. Ang Born to be Wild, ang ABS-CBN, may ara man TV-5 sir, nga ginpakita ang pag massage" (FGDP10).*

The river tour operators used flyers and brochures come in all shapes and sizes coming from the initiative of the local government agencies. They used flyers to announce new products or services which is a great way to let customers know about them. They also used it to describe the features and benefits of the product or service.

*"May mga flyers nga gin-ubra ni Belle Garido sa tourism, bale nag seminar kami sa province, tapos through kay sir Pie naghimo sa video" (FGDP09).*

The thematic analysis of the statements of the participants regarding the ways of promoting the river tour services is shown in Table 4.

**Table 4. Ways of Promoting River Tour Services**

| CODE     | CATEGORY               | Theme(s) Extracted              |
|----------|------------------------|---------------------------------|
| Facebook | Social Media Marketing | Promotional Tools for Marketing |
| TV       | Content Marketing      |                                 |
| Flyers   |                        |                                 |

The river tour operators used promotional tools as a way to build brand awareness to target customers. The river tour operators used attractive visuals which make sure the flyer design is eye-catching and includes high-quality visuals.

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### **Intervention/s can be Designed to Develop Sustainable Ecotourism**

There are a number of ways in which an intervention/program can be designed to develop sustainable ecotourism. A few key elements that should be included in such an intervention/program are as follows:

#### **Training and Capacity Building**

Another key element of developing sustainable ecotourism is by providing relevant training and capacity building for the river tour operators. The training and capacity building for the river tour operators will involve providing them with the necessary skills and knowledge to operate their business in a sustainable manner. This will include teaching them about the importance of conserving the environment, creating additional alternative sources of income, as well as how to properly manage their business in order to minimize the impact on the environment.

#### **Infrastructure Development**

Another important aspect of developing sustainable ecotourism is infrastructure development. This includes the development of basic infrastructures such as floating rafts and other sustainable tourism accommodations. It is important to develop the necessary facilities to accommodate the influx of tourists. This includes the development of adequate sanitation, electricity, as well as waste management facilities. The development of sustainable ecotourism also requires the participation of river tour operators. The community should be involved in the planning and development of the project from the very beginning.

### **(13) Conclusions and Recommendations**

#### **Conclusions**

Based on the findings of this study, the following conclusions are drawn:

1. Based on the gathered data, the members of the river tour operators are mostly middle-old age adults in terms of age groups. They complete formal education because of the financial capacity to support themselves from parents and family while studying. Most of them are single and others have children and live within the community. They are mostly from the family of fisherfolks who operated the river tour for a long time.
2. The services offered by the river tour operators before the occurrence of the pandemic such as (1) Mangrove, river and beach ecosystem, resource interpretation lecture, (2) rental of the floating raft for gatherings and meetings, (3) river tour in cabana and paddle boat experience, (4) selling of mangrove propagules for tree planting purposes, (5) community participation in mangrove planting and coastal clean-up, (6) foot spa, manicure/pedicure, and (7) body massage (by licensed massage therapists).
3. Tourists were satisfied with the river tour services. Some of the facilities of the river tour operators are subject for renovation.
4. The river tour operators used social media and content marketing through utilizing the platforms for promotional content to promote river tour services.
5. The feasible interventions for the river tour operators are training capacity building and infrastructure development. Training capacity building will help the river tour operators to get information about sustainable tourism practices and additional skills to address. The infrastructure development will help the river tour operators to get adequate facilities to run the business in sustainable ecotourism.

#### **Recommendations**

Based on the drawn conclusions, the following recommendations were formulated:

1. Further profiling and in-depth interviews with members of different river tour communities are strongly advised in order to broaden the intervention choices for future comparable research and extension projects.
2. The Local Government Unit of Roxas City (LGU-Roxas City) and other local government agencies should also help in the regular monitoring and evaluation of services of the river tour industry.
3. The Local Government Unit of Roxas City (LGU-Roxas City) and other local government agencies could provide funds for the renovation of the facilities and other support services needed by the river tour industry.
4. Promotional activities should be done regularly. There should also be regular monitoring and evaluation of the industry to test the effectiveness and efficacy of marketing.

|                                                                                   |                 |                                                |                |                           |
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5. Future researchers are encouraged to formulate a complete training program that can address other concerns of other river tour communities.

**(14) Output** (Indicate the specific products, processes or services which the project has produced; quantify when possible.)

**(15) Technology Transfer Activity Conducted** (Indicate the specific products, activity design, processes or services transferred as extension activities)

**(16) Economic Analysis** (This should present the direct cost of project implementation, expenses in the production of technology, revenues generated from technology produced, return on investment (ROI) and payback period.

**(17) Acknowledgments** (Include only important persons and institutions with involvement in funding and conduct of the research. Justify paragraphs with main headings in caps.)

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